boy, every time I went up to a United game she'd be there. She'd lean across her desk and give me a little kiss and the program she'd saved for me. Later on, Kath used to help me with answering my mail. She's part of United and she was with me right through my career there.

Whenever I came up to Manchester to train or to be at a game, I'd be looked after by Joe and Connie Brown, who had an office at the ground. They would take me—and Mum and Dad, if they were with me—around Old Trafford, take us for a meal, show us down to the dressing rooms and introduce us to the players and staff. Joe and Connie made me feel really welcome. Joe was Youth Development Officer at United. He was responsible for young players' expenses and travel arrangements but that job stretched to him and Connie taking care of just about everything when youngsters from outside Manchester and their families spent time at the club.

Then, when it came to the soccer, there was Nobby Stiles. I worked with Nobby after I joined the club, and he was really hard, just like he was as a player, but I think he cared more about the youngsters he worked with than anything else in the world. Dad knew all about Nobby as a player, of course, for United and as a World Cup winner with England: he and Dad got on really well, even though every now and again Nobby would have to catch himself about his language when he was getting carried away during one of our games:

'Excuse me, Mr Beckham. Excuse me, Mrs Beckham.'

Not that Dad was too worried about that:

'No problem, Nobby. You carry on.'

Nobby was great with us and he was great with our parents as well. He knew mums and dads needed to be involved, not treated as if they were in the way. If you watched videos or heard stories about him as a player, you'd never believe how gentle he was with the boys, or how polite he was with the parents. No-one took liberties with Nobby, mind. For all that he didn't look a big man and used to wear these huge glasses when he was coaching, he still had something about him you respected straight away. Fifteen years later, he would still come straight up and give me a big hug like nothing's changed since.

I could have moved up the year after I signed schoolboy forms, in August 1989, and finished my last two years of school in Manchester but, in the end, we decided I'd stay in London until I started full-time as a YTS trainee at